

The Prescription

The latest breed of handheld devices – tablets, have been glamourised by the iPad, and now everyone seems to want one. We give you the right prescription.

Harmanpreet Singh

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

Although the trend caught up recently, tablets have been here for quite a while. The concept of 'pen computing' started way back in 1980s, but slowly fizzled out due to lack of consumers. Then in the early 2000s, laptops were given a resistive touchscreen, that would swivel and close back, and roughly resemble today's tablet. But they never really compelled people to leave the keyboard and mouse combination.

The last few years have seen a large increase in wireless speeds, leading to the usual increase in our appetite for high quality media. The iPad arrived at a time when people wanted to consume videos in HD, games in 3D and web in all its glory – something the smartphone couldn't afford to do, due to limitations of screen estate and disk space. A flurry of manufacturers followed the iPad, to get a piece of the tablet pie. And so it was imperative for us to intervene, and separate the wheat from the chaff for you.

SAMSUNG GALAXY TAB

Samsung Galaxy Tab is one of the contenders for being the best Android tablet out there. Credit goes to Samsung, for keeping it light in weight and unnecessary customisations. So does it stand out among a galaxy of Android tablets?

The moment we laid our eager, dirty hands on this tablet, we left smudges on its glossy back and screen. A bad start, but the tablet has a near perfect build besides this. It is light yet solid, thanks to the high-grade plastic build. You can comfortably hold the tablet for

quite a while, though we would have liked it to be a few millimetres thinner. The screen is protected by the scratch-resistant Gorilla glass and has just enough bezel for a comfortable grip.

The first impression when switching it on was that the Android OS is much more stable on Galaxy Tab, than it was on little brother Galaxy S. The hardware seems well juiced and the device showed no lag whatsoever in UI or applications. The screen (TFT, not S-AMOLED) is decent, with good brightness levels.

The onscreen keyboard is little better than the stock Android keyboard, but presence of Swype in Android 2.2 helps.

Multi-touch and a good looking screen made it easy to love surfing on the device. Add to it FroYo's new Flash-trick and that almost completes the jigsaw. Flash-heavy websites take their toll on the device, it device handled 'almost' every site we threw at it.

The usual Google apps are accompanied by a few bundled apps by Samsung. Task Manager is the most useful of the lot, a feature that the Android OS still lacks. Reader's Hub is a one stop solution for reading newspapers, magazines or books. The bundled office suite is very basic, but seems enough to do minor editing on the go. Android 2.2's stock email application is good, with multiple inboxes and easy configuration for common mail servers.

The GPS navigation software is bundled by Google and works only in online mode, as it uses Google Maps service for maps. The lack of voice-guided, offline navigation might force you switch to a paid alternative, something people shouldn't need to do after spending ₹38,000 on a tablet.

Watching videos (upto 1080p) on the device is a pleasure, but the smudges



are a pain, especially in bright sunlight, where the screen itself does a good job.

The loudspeakers and bundled headphones churn out good sound, but no cable has been bundled for TV-out.

We often say, the magic of these new OSes lies in the app markets and the awesome apps they bring. Galaxy Tab has 'Samsung Apps' in addition to Android Market. At the time of writing, only one app was available in Samsung Apps: 'Need for Speed: Shift'.

The Market apps were all compatible with the Galaxy, even if they get a little pixelated while stretching to fit the 7 inch screen. Few compatible ones that we found by appending 'HD' to the search string looked good.

The tablet also has a 3.15 MP back camera and a VGA front camera. The video and photo quality is good for just casual clicking or video calling. The captured photos can be shared on Twitter, Facebook or Picassa directly through the Android gallery. Videos can be uploaded to YouTube equally effortlessly.

The battery life of the tablet is decent, unless you are a heavy gamer, in which case the device also gets a little warm. Also, if you are one to use your USB port to charge your gadgetry, you might as